If you have grown your own sweet corn, wait until the very last minute to harvest it—the quicker you get it from the plot to the pan, the sweeter it will be.

sweet corn chowder

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 1 MONTH
WITHOUT MILK OR CREAM CHEESE

4 fresh corn on the cob
2 cups water
sea salt
2 bay leaves
2 tbsp olive oil
1 large onion, chopped
4 fresh sage leaves, chopped, or ½ tsp dried sage, crushed
1 tsp fresh thyme leaves, or ½ tsp dried thyme
1 medium carrot, chopped
2 celery ribs, chopped
1 large potato, chopped
7oz (200g) cream cheese
½ cup milk
salt and freshly ground black pepper
half-and-half or heavy cream, to serve
dusting of paprika, to serve

1 Stand each corn cob upright in a large bowl, and strip the kernels by cutting downward with a sharp knife. Set the kernels aside. Place the cobs in a large saucepan and add the water, a generous dose of salt, and the bay leaves. Bring to a boil and simmer, covered, for 15 minutes. Remove and discard the cobs and bay leaves.

2 Heat the oil in a saucepan and cook the onions until translucent. Add the sage, thyme, carrot, celery, and potatoes. Cook for about 5 minutes, until softened. Add the corn cob stock and simmer until the potato softens. Meanwhile, place the corn kernels in a saucepan and barely cover with cold water. Bring to a boil and cook for 2 minutes. Set aside.

3 Add the cream cheese and milk to the soup mixture, then purée until smooth. Stir in the corn kernels with their cooking liquid. Give the chowder one more process if desired, to break up corn kernels slightly. Reheat, seasoning with salt and pepper to taste. Ladle into warm bowls. Drizzle with streaks of half-and-half and dust with paprika.